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Busy, Not Bountiful

Validating the Campus Apiary's Pollinator Index Against What's Actually Visiting the Garden Beds

Thandiwe Solberg · Osei Vandermeer — School of Continuous Improvement

Background

Sustainability reports biodiversity progress through the campus apiary's Pollinator Index, built entirely from six smart hives' weekly weight gain. Nobody has checked whether a heavier hive means a garden bed is doing any better by its wild visitors.

Aims

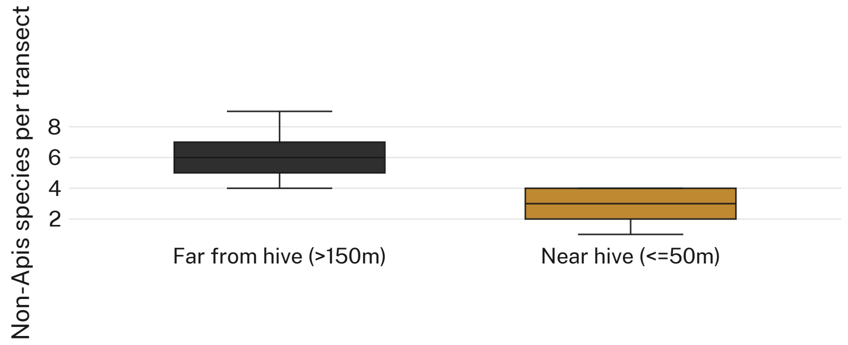
- Test whether the Pollinator Index predicts non-*Apis* richness in nearby beds
- Compare wild-pollinator richness near hives against matched far beds
- Establish whether the Index can carry the biodiversity claim made for it

Methods

- 6 smart hives · weekly weight logs · 14-week spring season
- 3 near (≤50m) + 3 far (>150m) beds · fortnightly 10-min timed transects · non-*Apis* species counts
- Observers blind to hive-weight data; Index formula unchanged from Sustainability's own

Results

The Pollinator Index rose 38% across the season. Near-hive richness showed no reliable relationship to weekly index value (r = 0.07) and sat persistently below far-bed richness throughout.



Near-hive richness held a median of 3 species (IQR 2–4) against 6 (IQR 5–7) at far beds every fortnight of the Sept–Dec 2025 season, while the Index it's meant to justify climbed 38% over the same period.

Discussion & conclusions

The Index, built from hive weight alone, predicts nothing about the pollinators it's cited to protect. The near/far gap was already there in week one, before the Index had moved. Next: a floral-resource survey before the Index anchors autumn's sustainability comms.

References

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Insect handling limited to visual identification; no specimens collected. Hive inspections followed routine apiary welfare protocol.

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"The index climbed all season. The garden beds nearby didn't."

Near-hive richness held at three species while the Pollinator Index rose 38% over 14 weeks.